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COMMUNITY CORNER

PARSHAS

NASO נשא



**YOM TOV
STARTS:**

**8:00 PM
(18 MINUTES)**

**YOM TOV
ENDS:**

**9:08 PM
(50 MINUTES)**

**TZAIS
HAKOCHAVIM:**

**9:31 PM
(72 MINUTES)**

Editor-in-chief: Doni Stern

Made possible by contributing writers throughout our community.

STORY OF THE WEEK By: Zechariah Lipitz



The walk was the highlight of the children's day. Each morning they woke up and eagerly waited for their beloved teacher to pass by, pick them up and escort them to school. The usual routine was the familiar knock at the door and a kiss on the cheek from their mother, and they were on their way. It was all to the credit of this new assistant teacher, said the townspeople amongst themselves. Since he had come, the children loved going to yeshiva. They were so attached to Reb Yisrael (later to be known as the Baal Shem Tov), and he, in his unique manner, succeeded in instilling within them fine character traits and fear of Heaven. He related to the children as a father. If a child was sick, Reb Yisrael went to his home immediately and fed him. At the same time, he bolstered the child's faith and trust in the Healer of the sick, our Father in Heaven. No wonder the parents relied on him implicitly and entrusted their children into his hands. The nearby forest was one of Reb Yisrael's favorite places. Every so often he would take the children there, and, surrounded by the wonders of nature, he would explain to them the greatness of the Creator. He told them of Jews who loved the mitzvot (commandments), of tzadikim (righteous people) who devoted their lives to G-d and to their fellow Jews, and implanted a deep love for G-d and His Torah within their hearts.

Reb Yisrael was a hidden tzadik. But one day, Reb Yisrael, who later came to be known as the Baal Shem Tov, revealed a little of his greatness. This is what happened: Getzel the Milkman related the horrifying news about a band of Cossacks who were approaching the area and were planning to attack their town. The Jews quickly stockpiled food and began preparing their hiding places, relying on cellars and attics as temporary shelters. As for the loss of property, they had already made peace with that misfortune. The main thing now was their lives, for they knew that an encounter with a Cossack would be fatal, G-d forbid. Reports they had heard from the survivors of nearby towns that had already been visited by the Cossacks were terrifying. Jews hid themselves and fearfully waited the arrival of the Cossacks. A group of Jews was in charge of watching over the food supply and dealing with any problem that might arise.

Reb Yisrael sat in the study hall consumed with worry. It wasn't that he was afraid, for his father had told him to fear nothing but G-d Himself. It was simply that his compassionate heart was broken with worry over the townspeople, especially for the innocent children, his students, who were hiding in fear, moaning in sorrow. They were so young, yet they were destined to suffer the lot of their fathers and grandfathers throughout the generations. Reb Yisrael wailed over the exile and cried out to G-d to annul the decree threatening the town. One day passed and then another. For an entire week, no one heard the sound of children singing in the morning. The town was deserted, with no signs of life. Who even remembered that tomorrow would be Lag B'Omer, Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai's day of celebration? This was the day that children traditionally went out to the fields and forests to play with bows and arrows. Only one person remembered the date, and that was Reb Yisrael. He remembered and resolved that this year would be no different. But what would the children's mothers say?

Night fell and word got around that the Cossacks were camping at the edge of the forest. Reb Yisrael didn't sleep that night. He prayed that the holiness of the day and the merit of the tzadik would stand by the townspeople and save them. Day broke and Reb Yisrael went to carry out his plan. Laden with bows and arrows, he visited the various hiding places and invited his charges out to the forest to play. The mothers couldn't bear the thought of parting with their little ones for even a moment, and to the forest of all places!

The children begged their mothers to allow them to accompany him. Reb Yisrael's holy, shining face encouraged the mothers to accede to their children's wishes. The deserted streets were now witness to a most peculiar procession. With Reb Yisrael in the lead, the children burst into song. They completely forgot the reason they had been hiding in the first place. The children went out to the field and celebrated Lag B'Omer! The Cossacks could hear the sounds of rejoicing. Who dared to irritate them this early in the morning?

They guided their horses in the direction of the noise, resolving to wipe out those insolent Jews. The hoof beats shook the town, the Cossacks approached closer and closer. Then, suddenly something amazing happened. As soon as the Cossacks saw the glowing face of the children's leader, fear filled their hearts.

They simply turned their horses around and left, never to return.

LOOK OUT FOR NEXT WEEK'S ISS

A FEW WORDS WITH...

ALAN ROSENSTOCK



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PARSHA QUESTION By: Gavriel Grodco

Which three activities were forbidden to the Nazir?

Stay tuned for the answer in the next Community Corner issue

Answer to last weeks parsha question:

Q. Why is the holiday called "Shavuot"?

A. Shavuot means "weeks," and it comes after counting seven weeks from the second day of Pesach.

THIS WEEK IN JEWISH HISTORY By: Avi Hirsch



May 24, 1948

Located 10 miles outside Jerusalem on a hilltop overlooking the Ayalon Valley, the fortress of Latrun was built by the British in 1940 after the Arab rebellion of 1936-1939. On May 14, 1948, as the British were evacuating their forces from Palestine, Jordan's Arab Legion took control of the fort. By controlling the fort at Latrun and the entrance to Jerusalem from the west, the Arab Legion was able to strengthen its siege on Jerusalem, which started in February and was isolating the 100,000 Jews in Jerusalem.

David Ben-Gurion believed that liberating Jerusalem was essential for the nascent state and that capturing Latrun was the key to liberating Jerusalem. Going against the advice of some of his top military advisers, including Yigal Allon, Ben-Gurion ordered the assault. The advance takes place in the early morning hours, and the Jordanian forces are helped by a full moon, which enables them to see the oncoming soldiers. Israeli forces have little experience fighting a regular army. Using outdated tactics without air support, the Israeli attack fails. Approximately 75 Israeli soldiers are killed. Two future prime ministers, Ariel Sharon and Yitzhak Rabin, were involved in the battle, and Sharon was wounded. Many of those killed in the attack are Holocaust survivors who arrived only days earlier from displaced-persons camps in Europe. They had no training, and virtually none of them spoke Hebrew. Three subsequent attacks on Latrun also failed to take the fortress. In June 1948, under the command of American Col. David "Mickey" Marcus, Israeli forces build the Burma Road as a bypass to Jerusalem. Israel does not capture Latrun until the Six-Day War in June 1967. Today the site is a tank museum and a memorial to fallen soldiers from Israel's Armored Corps.



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